

Teaching Statement

“Anyone other than Levi?” I was the front-row student, nodding, hand up before the question was finished. At the time, I assumed the silence around me was a matter of preference: some people just don't like to talk. As an instructor, I now see that I was wrong. Participation is mostly a product of the room, the very thing I control as the instructor. So I design for it, and my classrooms are lively.

When I come into class, I talk to my students before the session starts. Maybe I give them a riddle or tell them a fun fact. I ask them how they are. When class starts, I check in administratively as well. *Is anything confusing or unclear about what is expected of you?* When we launch into content, I often conduct discussions in what my favorite undergraduate professor would call “Socratic circles.” I rearrange the chairs into two distinct circles—one smaller circle inside a larger circle. The inner circle has a guided discussion about the topic of the day for some allotted amount of time (often between 10 and 20 minutes). Meanwhile, the outer circle observes and analyzes the discussion—not focusing on their opinion of the content nor who they agree with. Instead, they analyze *how the discussion went*. Did it flow? Did someone dominate? Was it a debate or did everyone agree? What would you like to see repeated when it's your turn? What would you avoid? Why? When the inner circle's discussion ends, the outer circle reports their analysis *out loud* while the inner circle listens. Then the circles switch and the process repeats. I have never guided nor participated in a more successful discussion-based in-class philosophy exercise. I appreciate that the inner circle gets the room to speak while the attention on them encourages considerate behavior. Then the outer circle learns to see a discussion *as a discussion* rather than waiting to add one's own opinion on the matter. They learn to listen to a structure. Students report loving this exercise and my smaller ethics courses adopted it as a classroom standard.

If half the work of fostering a lively classroom is in curating the atmosphere, the other half is two distinct syllabus mechanisms. Firstly, I define participation explicitly and stay true to it: engaged contribution in a stated number of sessions, explained and posted on the first day of class, with a record kept of who speaks each session. Second, my "keyword discussions" give students a set of named roles to discuss from, roles such as: Excavator, who surfaces an unstated premise; Contrarian, who tests the argument; Complexifier, who troubles a framed binary. Along with five others. Students choose a role for each post, and by the end of the semester every student must have performed all eight. The roles give students with strong opinions somewhere to put them, and give students with no settled view a legitimate way into the discussion. Figuring out exactly how to set up a discussion during class, having these roles in mind, has definitely required experimentation. I once tried implementing a chess-style timer for allotting time to speak, but it just made the distribution of engagement much more apparent while offering no solution. So instead I focused on being a grounding facilitator of conversation, and it worked much better.

I build assessment on the same principle as I define participation: make the standard explicit, then let students choose how to meet it. My ethics courses run this way, for example. The final exam opens on the first day of the semester and is tiered: Level 1 identifies the ethical theories we cover, Level 2 draws out the practical obligations each theory entails, Level 3 applies a theory to a case we studied. In my writing-intensive courses, the term paper is scaffolded: two staged "prospective ideas," the first drawn from students' own entering interests and the second from course material, then a paper-writing workshop, then the paper, with a final-exam alternative for students the essay format does not serve.

My classes operate under the guiding notion that philosophy rewards textual and argumentative precision: reading closely, writing exactly, following an argument where it actually goes. But that is just what it takes to get the degree, and has almost nothing to do with how to teach it. Knowing something and getting a room full of undergraduates to care about it are painfully different skills, and the gap between them has grown enormous now that a language model will produce a competent paragraph on basically anything I teach. What a philosophy classroom still offers that nothing else does is live, face-to-face, unscripted discussion between people. That, too, I can teach. I always keep my own commitments out of the room. What I enforce instead is at minimum an argumentative standard: state the strongest version of the position you are arguing against, charitably enough that someone who holds it would recognize herself in it. That one rule has set the tone of entire discussions and is in fact the one thing I most want students to carry out with them, even if they never take another philosophy course again.